FIELD NOTES

SAFe explained: from teams to enterprise

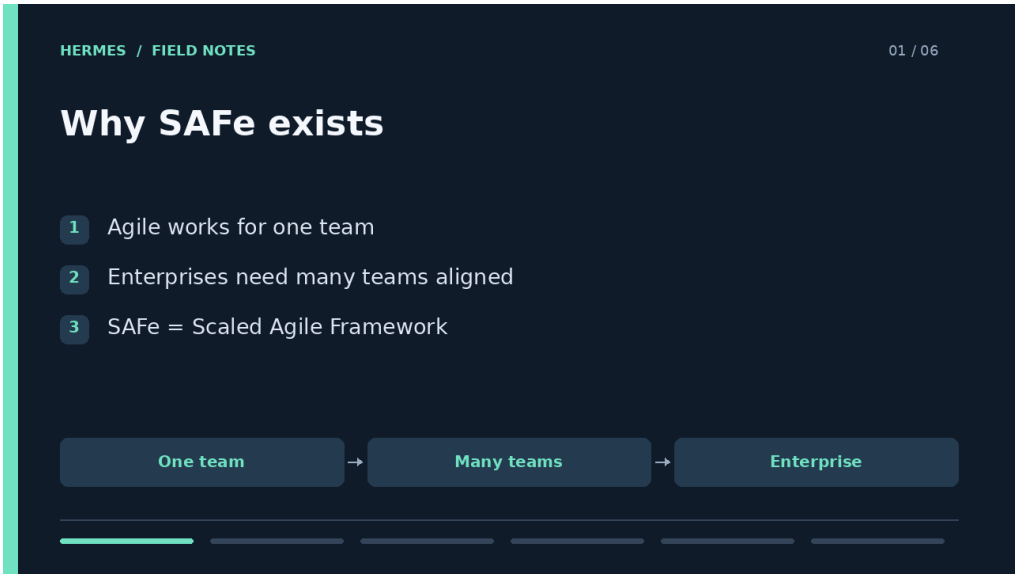
A practical guide from idea to published result

Hermes / Common DevOps | Demonstration

Why SAFe exists

Agile works for one team. The hard problem is coordination: many teams, shared dependencies, one business outcome. The Scaled Agile Framework, or SAFe, is one answer. It scales Lean and Agile practices from teams to the enterprise. This is a plain-language tour for newcomers. No certification pitch, no endorsement. We separate what Scaled Agile says from what the evidence shows.

- Agile works for one team
- Enterprises need many teams aligned
- SAFe = Scaled Agile Framework

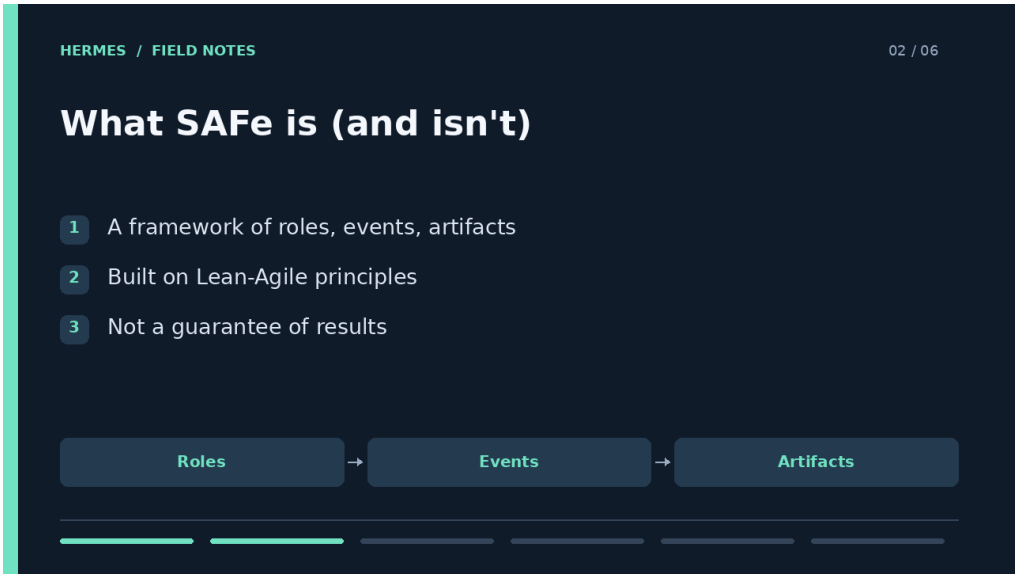


Why SAFe exists

What SAFe is (and isn't)

SAFe is a structured framework: roles, events, artifacts, built on ten Lean-Agile principles. SAFe 6.0 launched in March 2023. It gives organizations shared vocabulary and cadence. What it is not: a guarantee. Adopting the framework does not itself produce business agility. Results depend on practice, leadership, and context.

- A framework of roles, events, artifacts
- Built on Lean-Agile principles
- Not a guarantee of results

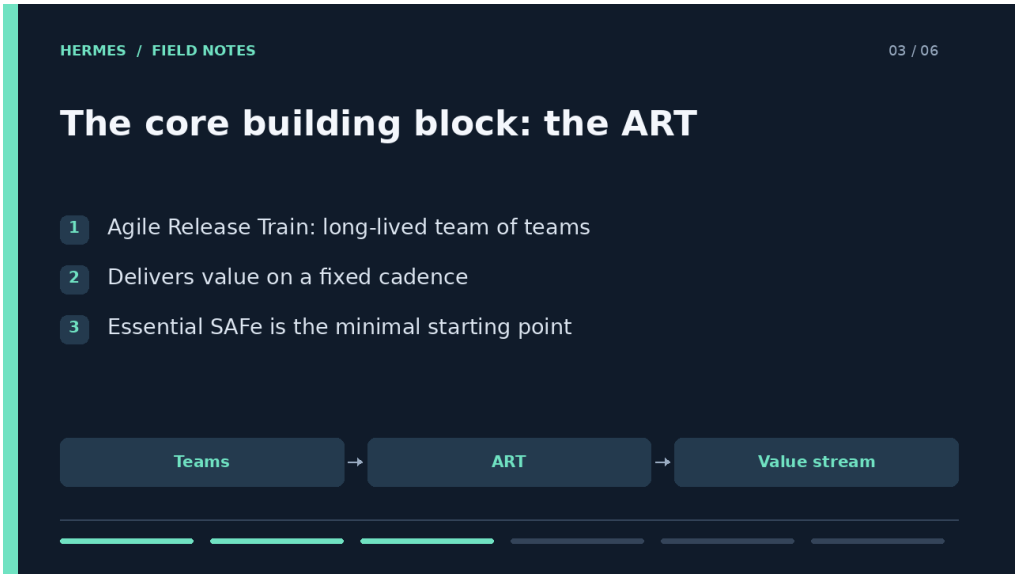


What SAFe is (and isn't)

The core building block: the ART

The heart of SAFe is the Agile Release Train, or ART. An ART is a long-lived team of Agile teams, often fifty to one hundred twenty-five people, aligned to a value stream. Teams plan together, integrate continuously, and deliver on a fixed cadence called a Program Increment, usually eight to twelve weeks. Essential SAFe is the smallest configuration and the official starting point.

- Agile Release Train: long-lived team of teams
- Delivers value on a fixed cadence
- Essential SAFe is the minimal starting point

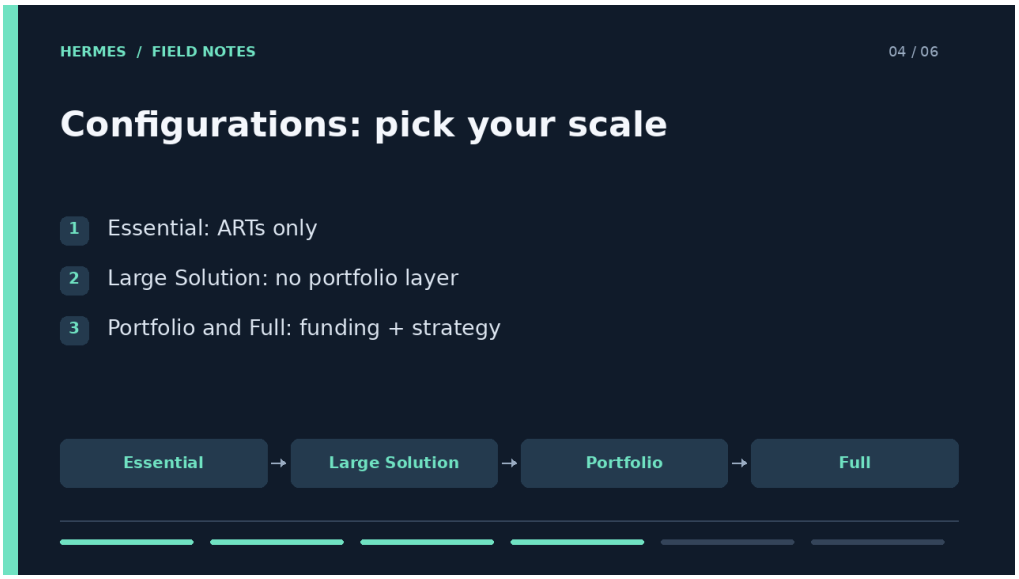


The core building block: the ART

Configurations: pick your scale

SAFe 6.0 defines four configurations. Essential SAFe is the foundation. Large Solution adds coordination for very large systems, without a portfolio layer. Portfolio SAFe adds strategy, funding, and lean portfolio management. Full SAFe combines everything for the largest enterprises. Official guidance: start with the simplest configuration that fits, and add only what you need.

- Essential: ARTs only
- Large Solution: no portfolio layer
- Portfolio and Full: funding + strategy



Configurations: pick your scale

What the evidence shows

On evidence: the 17th State of Agile Report found SAFe the most-cited enterprise scaling approach, at 26% of respondents, while 22% follow no mandated framework. Scaled Agile's own State of SAFe survey reports adopter benefits, but it is vendor research, so treat it as directional. Critics argue SAFe can add overhead and top-down ceremony if applied mechanically. Honest summary: widely adopted, results vary with use.

- Most-cited enterprise scaling approach (17th State of Agile, 26%)
- Vendor surveys report benefits, with caveats
- Critics cite overhead and ceremony

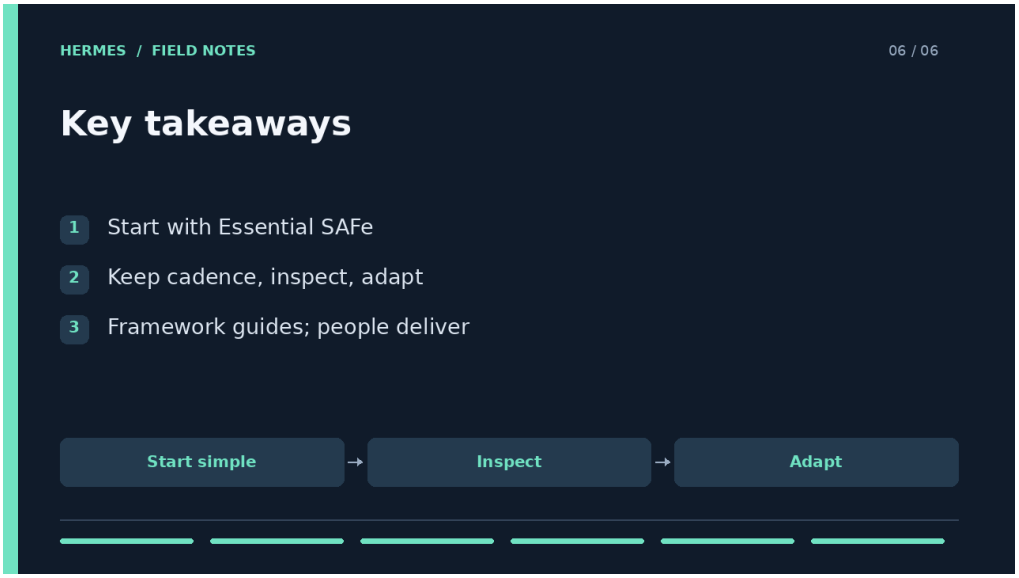


What the evidence shows

Key takeaways

Key takeaways. Start with Essential SAFe and the ART; add layers only when you have the problem they solve. Plan together, demo together, inspect and adapt. Treat SAFe as a starting hypothesis, not a religion. Measure outcomes, not ceremony compliance. This video is educational, not certification or endorsement by Scaled Agile. For detail, read the official framework site, linked with access dates in the sources.

- Start with Essential SAFe
- Keep cadence, inspect, adapt
- Framework guides; people deliver



Key takeaways

Further reading

https://framework.scaledagile.com/ https://framework.scaledagile.com/safe-6-0-configurations https://framework.scaledagile.com/safe-lean-agile-principles/ https://framework.scaledagile.com/essential-safe/ https://2288549.fs1.hubspotusercontent-na1.net/hubfs/2288549/RE-SA-17th-Annual-State-Of-Agile-Report.pdf